

Melbourne Uni seeks to solve its 'student problem'

Reform University's vice-chancellor sees opportunity for change.

Julie Hare

Australia's most highly ranked and wealthiest university has a problem: its students rank it last out of 139 higher education institutions on the quality of their student experience.

Add ongoing issues with underpayment of casual staff – now around \$31 million – and when Melbourne University's vice-chancellor Duncan Maskell says it is "one of the finest universities, anywhere" he also acknowledges there is "work to be done".

The work goes to the culture of an institution that has produced the most Nobel laureates in the country – eight – and which has transformed large chunks of Melbourne into thriving research-based precincts.

Yet many of its students and staff are not enamoured with the place.

Earlier this year, Professor Maskell put in place a strategy to address the disquiet. It will run in tandem with a national review of Australia's higher education sector that will examine whether it is producing the graduates the future economy needs, is fair and equitable, and has policies and funding to drive a dynamic research sector.

The review, to be run by Mary O'Kane, former NSW chief scientist and engineer, has a wide brief.

What it will mean for an institution such as Melbourne, with its \$2.8 billion in revenues, 56,000 students, 10,000 staff and \$1.3 billion endowment, is anyone's guess. The last major review of the sector, known as the Bradley review, made some radical but not enduring changes, but left Melbourne mostly untouched.

If the chief aim of the Bradley review of 2008 was to increase the number of young people attending university to 40 per cent, then it was a roaring suc-

cess. In a decade, the proportion of under-35s with a degree rose from 29 per cent to 44 per cent.

With its groundbreaking model of broad undergraduate degrees leading into professional postgraduate degrees, known as the Melbourne Model, the university was exempted from the uncapping of domestic student places, known as the demand-driven system.

So while institutions across the country doubled and trebled in size, Melbourne's domestic enrolments remained relatively static.

However, Bradley's other key target, to increase those from the poorest quartile of students attending university to 20 per cent, failed.

As cynics will say, the vast increase in student numbers came from the middle classes – rich and dumb – not from the harder-to-attract poor. They abandoned TAFE for university, which produced its own bevvy of problems.

Like other elite institutions, Melbourne barely budged the dial on equity. Data from the National Centre for the Study of Equity in Higher Education shows that between 2013 and 2019, the number of low socio-economic students at the university increased by just 23. Regional enrolments declined by 400, while Indigenous enrolments doubled but still added up to only 223.

Equity is close to Maskell's heart, based on first-hand experience. When he was growing up in north London, his dad was a maintenance superintendent for the local borough and his mother worked in a factory making darts and dartboards. While at school, he had a job at the local W.H. Smith bookstore, "baling up the waste cardboard, emptying the bins, sweeping the floors and cleaning the toilets".

The family lived in a council house before selling it and moving into a "nice suburban semi-detached".

Maskell proved to have had social mobility coded into his DNA. Good at school, he was the rare working-class kid who in 1979 scored a place to study science at Cambridge. There were no



The upcoming review of higher education must balance excellence and equity with the national interest, says vice-chancellor Duncan Maskell. PHOTO: ELKE MIETZEL

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Duncan Maskell

fees and he received a means-tested stipend, which meant he had to work only in his holidays. During semester, he could commit himself fully to study and university life.

"It's something I wish was still the case for our current students," he says. He rails against utilitarian perceptions of universities as factories for the production of a skilled workforce, saying his undergraduate experience "helped me to understand the world a lot better and introduced me to many new things I hadn't thought about".

It's what he likes about the Melbourne Model: young people get to spend their undergraduate years discovering who they are and what it is they are passionate about, before com-

mitting themselves to a profession.

Melbourne students, however, have lately given the university a bad rap. In August, an annual student experience survey placed Melbourne last out of 139 higher education institutions, with just 63.1 per cent of its students positive about their overall experience. It's not a statistic any vice-chancellor wants on their CV. Maskell says addressing this is now an institutional priority.

"I was very unhappy when that statistic came through. The glib answer is the survey was done in the middle of the second [COVID-19] lockdown in Melbourne, so all the Victorian universities did less well than they might otherwise have done. But it's not the real answer. And we are doing a lot of work to understand that score."

He also has no clear answer as to why Melbourne graduates perform relatively poorly on graduate salaries, an oddity given the intellectual clout the university attracts. "A lot of our students do move into leadership positions, but maybe not in that first period after they leave university," he says.

"But also because most of our undergraduates go into master's courses, we are unfairly treated by the statistics because only a small percentage of new graduates go directly into jobs."

When asked what aspect of Melbourne he is particularly proud of, Maskell points to the world-class biomedical precinct in Parkville. There is the law school, which has been ranked seventh-best in the world, and inventions such as the Monty hood – a retractable ventilation hood for hospital beds to help reduce spread of COVID-19, which has since been adopted across the state and been spun out into a company.

Maskell is an old hand at spin-outs. A microbiologist with a focus on infectious diseases, he moved into senior roles at Cambridge, including as head of the department of veterinary medicine and school of biological sciences, and as senior pro vice-chancellor responsible for planning and resources, with a budget of about \$3.5 billion. He has also successfully spun out three companies. A fourth failed and is about to be restructured.

"Previous success is no guarantee of continuing success," he says.

Having worked closely with big pharmaceutical companies, Maskell says universities can get a little arrogant in the belief that they have a monopoly on "smart people".

"There can be this sort of intellectual arrogance about people in leading universities that says 'we're all smart and people who go into industry are second rate'. Well, it's just not true," he says.

If Melbourne and its ilk in Australia are to compete with Oxbridge, the Ivy League and a rising number of Chinese universities, then the federal government must provide secure research funding that does not eat into institutional resources, he says.

"It's a constant struggle to make sure we have extra revenues to conduct research. And it is my contention that the money we receive per student for teaching is not enough to teach them. We have to go somewhere else to get that money. I'm not whingeing, but it's the reality," he says.

That "somewhere else" is, of course, international students. In 2020, Melbourne brought in \$845 million in fees from overseas students, nearly three times the amount it attracted in 2011.

"Any government will decide what is the right level of research it wants to fund. But in general, research should be seen as an investment, not money sent down the drain," Maskell says.

In the meantime, Professor Mary O'Kane will lead a new review of higher education policies that in many ways looks like Bradley 2.0.

Labor's university review must consider fairness and quality

Tertiary studies

Max Yong



Education Minister Jason Clare last week announced the first major review of higher education policy since 2008. Among other things, it will re-examine the previous government's Job-ready Graduates policy that led to a radical change in university funding, most notably 113 per cent price increases for arts and humanities students.

Job-ready Graduates was supposed to give students incentives to enrol in what the government considered high-priority areas such as teaching and agriculture with rock-bottom fees of \$4000 a year.

It was also supposed to discourage students from studying courses that the government determined were of less value to the labour market, such as arts and humanities, with record-high annual fees of \$15,000.

I conducted the first data-driven

economic review of Job-ready Graduates, and found that these price signals didn't work. Fee changes do not affect student decision-making because HECS-HELP payments are made years after a student enrolls in their course.

So, what should the Labor government do instead?

First, it might be a good idea to go back to first principles and realign course fees with expected private returns. This means courses that are reasonably expected to result in higher incomes, such as medicine and law, incur higher course fees. It is only fair that courses that result in lower average salaries, such as social work and creative arts, enjoy lower fees.

Note that HECS-HELP loans ensure that no one repays anything until their income is in the 35th income percentile (about \$48,000), and debts do not grow in real terms because they are indexed to CPI. This ensures graduates are not crippled by their debt as in the US.

This alignment is fair for students and improves the probability that

student debt is repaid because those owing the most will earn the highest incomes on average. It is more equitable than the Greens' policy to return to a Whitlam-era policy of zero fees, which is regressive in nature and therefore unfair. It is not equitable for the average taxpayer to pay for trust-fund students' law degrees.

A large focus of the higher education review, known as the accord, is to ensure that higher education provides the labour market with "skills needed now and in the future". Instead of trying to use fees to ineffectively sway students' decision-making, there are more appropriate options available.

A marketing campaign that targets students as they are forming university study plans is a much cheaper alternative. Informing a year 10 student that a graduate teacher earns \$75,000 – more than \$10,000 above the average graduate salary – could certainly sway undecided students.

Targeted upfront cash scholarships could also encourage students to choose high-priority study areas. Even

a \$5000 scholarship would probably be influential, where half is paid upfront and the other half at graduation.

The accord panel would need to consider ways to target this to specific student demographics, such as low socio-economic, and areas of study, such as agriculture.

In the terms of reference, Clare makes it clear that he wants to "support greater access and participation for students from underrepresented backgrounds, including First Nation Australians, those from low socio-economic backgrounds, people with disability, and regional and rural Australians".

The best way to address this is via the welfare system, with changes in the parental means test, the age of independence, rental assistance, and level of Youth Allowance. Because HECS-HELP removes the upfront cost of university tuition, the largest financial barrier is the living expenses associated with student life. I'm not talking about textbooks and laptops, but food, rent and healthcare.

Access to Youth Allowance removes this immediate financial burden, allowing low socio-economic status and disadvantaged students to pursue their goals. The Greens and the National Union of Students have been campaigning on this issue for years.

While the terms of reference for the accord are wide, they are focused on the Department of Education.

However, Youth Allowance decisions sit in the Department of Social Services, a separate silo. The accord panel, led by Professor Mary O'Kane, needs a holistic approach to improving access for underrepresented Australians.

Abolishing fees for these students will not work because it doesn't change their ability to support themselves through three or more years of study.

Other important issues for the panel include ensuring high-quality teaching and research, and diversifying the international student export market away from China.

Maxwell Yong is an economics honours student at The University of Melbourne.